

Earthquakes

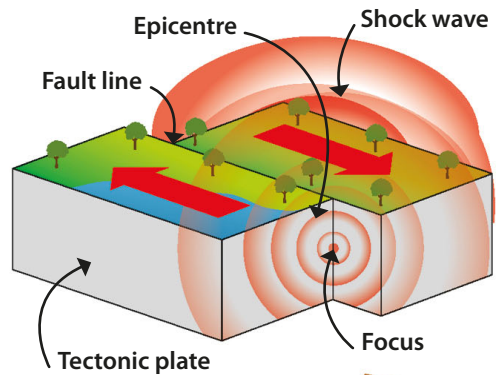
When the rocky tectonic plates that form Earth's crust move suddenly, large waves of energy spread out, causing the ground to shake. This is an earthquake. Some earthquakes are fairly gentle and may even go unnoticed, but others can bring terrible destruction.

Earthquake crack

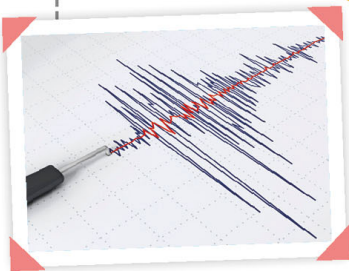
An earthquake can cause large cracks to open up in the Earth's surface. Many are small, no more than a few metres deep or wide, but others are massive, and whole buildings can fall into them.

What causes an earthquake?

The plates in Earth's crust constantly slide past each other, but can get stuck. Pressure then builds up until the plates finally move, sending out shock waves. The focus of an earthquake is the point inside the ground where pressure builds up. The epicentre is the point on the surface above the focus.



1-2



Seismograph

This machine is used to measure the force of the vibrations caused by an earthquake. It records how powerful these vibrations are on a numbered scale.

2.5-4



Mild tremors

Earthquakes that a seismograph records as having a force of 2.5-4 are felt as mild tremors. They cause little or no damage, although trees may sway and windows rattle.

5-6

